



Family Transformation in the Colonial Context of German Togo

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Abstract. – This article concerns administrative and cultural mechanisms that the colonial government and the Catholic Steyler missionaries (SVD) in German Togo were using in the process of transforming the traditional social fabric of local ethnic groups – the process that had also a significant impact on the institution of family by altering community-based African conceptions about the human being. Those administrative and cultural tools of social disciplining were supported by the contemporary ideological framework composed of Christian, positivist and nationalist components. The example of the family of Martin Aku – Togolese intellectual and political activist – illustrates the effectiveness of that system. The phenomenon that contradicted the then mainstream ideology of white superiority was the growing number of individuals of mixed ancestry – the “unwanted fruit” of liaisons between European colonial agents and indigenous women.¹ [*German Togo, colonial practical ideology, disciplining, habitus, culture change*]

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1. German Togo: a Stage of the Colonial Drama

The German colonial polity of Togo was established on July 5, 1884, and it later expanded in a

particular geographical and sociohistorical context whose principal characteristic was the North-South bipolarity – the divide between the tropical and largely Ewe-speaking coastal belt that had been part of the Atlantic trading system for centuries, on the one hand, and the dry, ethnically differentiated northern region, politically dominated by Muslim statelets and integrated into the indigenous Hausa trading complex, on the other.²

While the German colonial state, in general, conformed to the precolonial spatiality, it also modified it significantly. This was accomplished by means of application of modern technology, reorganization of labor, urbanization, as well as the expansion of communication and transportation infrastructure. In short, the colonial institutions, and hence the main channels of structural and ideological transformation of local societies, were concentrated mostly in the south of the colony.

2. The African Notion of Human Being

Before discussing specific mechanisms of social transformation in German Togo, it is necessary to outline what is generally referred to as “African conceptions about human being” – that is, on what was being transformed, or acted upon, by institu-

¹ For a more extended discussion of colonial policies in German Togo see also Darius J. Piwowarczyk (2017).

² During their three-decade rule in Togo, Germans did not entirely succeed in closing that divide. The South-North divide had been even administratively sanctioned for a period of about seven years. In 1907, the colonial government declared that Europeans (in the first place missionaries) could cross the line Kpedja – Kete-Krachi (a conventional demarcation between the South and the North) only with permission of corresponding authorities.

tions of the colonial state and by missions. In order to understand the sub-Saharan notion of human being, one needs to overcome, in the first place, the dualistic dichotomy between the immaterial soul and material body typical for the Western understanding of the persona. African cultures conceptualize personhood by identifying in it a number of onto-sociological aspects, some of which cannot be precisely rendered in English (Sündermeier 1988: 18). Moreover, a family group, or a clan, is regarded as a community of the living and the dead, and even those not yet born – a social unit in which the past, the present, and the future come together. Put it differently, what really constitutes a traditionally thinking African man or woman are relations, and not the unique, individual persona as it is the case in the Judeo-Christian tradition. In the West, one can often repeat the Cartesian *cogito ergo sum*: “I think and therefore I exist”; an Ewe or a Fon person would say instead: “I belong to, therefore I exist.” Accordingly, community in its multiple dimensions is the given, the principle framework of personal reference. It extends also beyond the perceptible social world, and as such it includes the world of animals, the realms of ghosts, of ancestors, and of the divine, while the ancestors – the deceased members of the clan – constitute the bridge between the living and gods.

3. Ideological Underpinnings for Colonial Intervention

These local conceptions about human being were confronted by a complex ideological system brought by Europeans that was composed of Christian, nationalist, and positivist-Darwinist components. A classical exposal of Catholic missionary ideology of that time was the book by the Catholic missiologist, Joseph Schmidlin (1876–1944), published in 1913 and entitled: *Die katholischen Missionen in den deutschen Schutzgebieten* (“The Catholic Missions in the German Protectorates”). In the chapter “The Question of Principles: Mission and Colonial Institutions,” Schmidlin stated, for example, that “the colonial era of the 1870s and the 1880s was also a milestone in the history of Christian missions” and pointed to a dialectical interdependence, in fact a synthesis of missions and European administrations in the colonial field. In this context, Schmidlin emphasized the “cultural activity” (*kulturelle Tätigkeit*) of Catholic missions which he regarded as the supplementation and en-

dorsement of economic and political dimensions of colonialism. The complementary role of missions in the colonial field, according to Schmidlin, consisted in conducting the “spiritual conquest” – that is to say, in making the subdued population *want* to obey – while the administration brings them to obedience by *coercion*. He wrote in this regard: “The mission conquers our colonies spiritually and assimilates them internally... The government can enforce external obedience through laws and punishment but the mental submission, indeed the securing of people’s loyalty, can be accomplished only by the mission.” In fact, the “spiritual conquest” can be achieved only by combining persuasion with disciplining, and specifically – by Christianization, schooling, and “training natives for work,” which elevates local population to a “higher cultural” level and, above all, provides colonies with properly trained indigenous personnel (Schmidlin 1913: 276ff.; transl. - DJP).

The common denominator of both missionary and government programs in German Togo (and elsewhere in Europe-dominated Africa) was, nonetheless, the issue of “progress” – the principal motif of the then dominant narrative, indeed the “first ideological mover” of the West European civilization at the turn of the nineteenth and twentieth century. Thus, for Bernhard Dernburg (1865-1937) – director of Colonial Department in Berlin in the years 1907-1910 – who sought to harmonize the purposes of economic exploitation, efficient administration, and “progress” of indigenous populations, colonization meant “the utilization of land, its mineral resources, its flora and fauna and, above all, people for the benefit of the colonizing nation that, in turn, commits itself to give in return its higher culture, its moral conceptions, and its better technology” (Längin 2005: 39; transl. - DJP). Under the term “better technology,” Dernburg was certainly referring to what Adas (1993) later named the closing of “technological gauge” between the modernized Western self and the non-European other, and specifically the perception of a civilizatory rift separating Westerners from inhabitants of the colonial frontier that was measured in terms of the degree of technological sophistication. Moreover, the technological divide between the colonizer and the colonized was often rendered as a difference in degree of humanization. This notion was telling conveyed by a contemporary German poster showing an airplane overflowing a group of apish-looking Africans who seem to be afraid of what they see and hear (Fig. 1).



Fig. 1: Perceived “technological gap” between Europe and Africa (Zeller 2010: 63)

The colonial ideology at the turn of the nineteenth- and twentieth century was founded not only on various currents of Christian theology and on the Positivist notion of progress, but also on elements of Cultural Darwinism which in some instances even took the form of a radical racism. The writings of Paul (Karl Albert) Rohrbach (1869-1956) are a good case in point. Rohrbach was a trained Protestant theologian, political publicist, and colonial propagandist. He also served as a colonial official in German South-West Africa (today Namibia) in the years 1903-1906. Perhaps the most explicit exposal of Rohrbach’s views is his article concerning the relationship between mixed marriages and “racial dignity” in South-West Africa, published in 1912. He stated: “I spent a number of years in South-West Africa, where I had a chance to observe consequences of mixed marriages and liaisons between natives and whites, and I can summarize my experience in the following words: marriages between whites and blacks are quite a misfortune at the present time and a true sin against the future” (Gründer 1999: 287; transl. - DJP). The Rheinisch Missionary Society, the leading missionary organization active in South-West Africa at that time, “did not welcome” such marriages, Rohrbach continued, but as the marriage in church counted as the civil one at that

time, the missionaries made a virtue out of necessity and “the churchly legitimization of such relations was granted.” In the final section of his article, Rohrbach presented the “terrible results of “the so-called marriages,” as he now termed them: “the pernicious moral level of the offspring, disorder in the household, and the damage caused to the household economy by the relatives of the female, who considered it as their right to live off the house’s resources.” What one observes, in this situation, Rohrbach concluded, was not “the cultural elevation and education of natives but rather the degradation of white men, to the point of their actual *Verkafferung* – that is, “blackening” or “going native” (Gründer 1999: 289; transl. - DJP).

4. State-Induced Disciplinary Practices and their Impact on the Family

In this section, I focus on various administrative means of inculcating these nineteenth-century European values in Togolese colonial subjects, and on the impact of those practices on family life. Those organized efforts aimed, in the first place, at dismantlement of the “traditional African” concept of human being, especially on the redrawing the conceptual boundary between the individual and society, and its redefinition in terms of the West-European personhood. Mechanisms that the German administration was using in the process of shaping a docile colonial subject were, among other things, “correctional settlements,” military barracks, and schools.

The correctional settlements (*Besserungssiedlungen*) were quintessential examples of the disciplinary practices in German Togo. One of them was located on the Chra River, about 125 kilometers north of Lome, and the other – Djabotaure near Blita – on the northern frontier, in the district Sokode-Bassari. The Chra colony was founded in 1902. Individuals sent to that settlement were people “with criminal past,” or rather those whom the local administration classified as such. In 1907, for instance, the station officer responsible for the district of Sansane-Mangu, First Lieutenant Adolf Mellin, sent to Chra nine “habitual vagabonds” who had already been previously convicted but who were still seen as “harmful” to society (Asmis 1911: 535). Interestingly, the convicts were mostly people representing the ethnic groups from the “unpacified” northern frontier, in particular the Konkomba. The settlement was envisioned as a “model African village” (according to colonial standards), and indeed by the year 1910 it had ac-

quired the aspect of “a flourishing native village with vibrant traffic and commercial exchange,” as Asmis put it. By the year 1909, the total number of inhabitants of the Chra station reached 258 individuals, including 84 men, 83 women, and 91 children.

The correctional colony in Chra was also a site of cultural exchange – the melting pot where a new, “Togolese” colonial culture began to take form. Asmis observed, for example, that convicts initially erected houses in their own, ethnic-specific styles. After certain time, however, a new type of architecture emerged that was inspired primarily by local Ewe craftsmen, some of them perhaps trained at the Styler mission workshop located in Atakpame. Another important factor contributing to the process of cultural “leveling,” as Asmis named it, was intermarriage, although “a few Moslem families from the district Sansane-Mangu (were) too proud to give their daughters as wives to men from (other) tribes.” Finally, the authorities also intended to unify the settlers linguistically by promoting Ewe as the main language of communication. It was hoped that the mission school and the contact with “more civilized” neighbors would help to establish Ewe as the lingua franca in Chra (Asmis 1911: 537f.). The intended “final product” of disciplining in correctional settlements was to be a “diligent farmer” competent in modern agricultural techniques and producing cash crops for the German market. This process was facilitated by the fact that a large number of convicts were individuals whose bonds to their communities of origin had already been loosened, and who had already lived in the interstice between their indigenous cultural universe and the emerging colonial society.

Another institutional mechanism of shaping Togolese colonial subject was the *Polizeitruppe* – the military arm of the German administration. Obviously, the “ritual” of military drill concerned only a selected group of individuals who volunteered for service in the troop. Not all of them were Togolese natives either; in fact the initial policy, adopted for security reasons, was to recruit men from outside of the colony (primarily the Hausa from Nigeria and the Vai from Liberia), and thus to create a unit that would be ethically alien to Togo’s population. Another loyal group of servicemen constituted members of Togolese ethnic groups whose bonds with communities of origin had been severed (i.e. ex-slaves), and who, therefore, considered the troop as their “family.” The training was conducted according to German, in fact Prussian standards of military proficiency, or-

derliness, and discipline. The good pay allowed men to support large families and a number of Moslems troopers had officially two or more wives. It is important to add here that the bride price in the southern districts of the colony amounted to a respectable 150 marks (Morlang 2008: 33f.).³

5. The Contribution of Missions to the Colonial Process of Transformation of Togolese Families

“Interreligious dialogue” and “intercultural competence,” two catchwords of the present-day institutional discourse of the Steyler Missionaries and the Steyler Mission Sisters, were certainly not part of their missionary agenda at the turn of the nineteenth and twentieth century. What missionaries expected from the Togolese was a possibly complete adoption of cultural codes that were, by and large, distinctive for subordinated sectors of German society. This process was discursively euphemized as cultural “advancement,” ontological betterment in this life, and a way to win salvation hereafter. The principal two mechanisms applied in the process were schooling and religious rituals.

5.1. Schooling

The training of Togolese girls at schools operated by the Steyler orders in Lome and Anecho was based on the ideological principles presented above. Fr. Bücking wrote, for instance, in 1901: “Besides the teaching of writing and reading, the emphasis is placed on the acquisition of religious knowledge, as well as on the introduction of girls into the necessary practical housework skills, with the purpose of laying foundation for good, monogamous, Christian families” (transl. - DJP).⁴ Obviously, talking about the “necessary practical skills,” Bücking disregarded multiple competences that the children had already acquired in the process of socialization in their families and communities. Instead, the missionary education was to give them the knowledge and habits that were

³ The amount of 150 DM was equivalent to about 1000 euro today (in 1900, 1 DM= 6.70 €).

⁴ *Stand der Togomission vom Jahre 1901*; Presse Togo, p. 54; Archive of SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536.

“necessary for living” in the “piece of Germany” that was emerging in Togo. Moreover, the transmission and inculcation of such skills and habits were seen as the elevation of “deeply degraded” (*tief gesunken*) African women, as Fr. Schönig put it, to a higher *Kultur*, and hence to a “higher ontological status.”⁵ Another Steyler missionary, while praising, “in general,” the diligence and industriousness of native women from the area of Porto Seguro, viewed them as “driven by natural instincts” (*naturwüchsig*) and “frivolous” (*ausgelassen*), and therefore barely capable of creating a family characterized by “Christian values and probity.” The reason for that, the author suggested, was not so much of biological but rather of cultural nature: “The fetish had kept them under control from their childhood on.”⁶

Missionaries also put emphasis on training future native Catholic teachers, and these were, almost exclusively, men. In order to ensure a thorough “reform” of their habits, the candidates (aged 12-14) were to be placed under the regime of a boarding school (*Internatsschule*) for a period of 7-9 years, and hence largely separated from their family and native cultural environment. During their *Internat* formation, the candidates remained under strict control of the mission superior: he had to hold periodical conferences for them, evaluate their performance, and address all professional and moral issues that may have concerned them. As part of the colonial program of “training Negroes for work,” they were also expected to establish and tend their own gardens in order to generate “a little income.”

Although the system of formal education was in itself a colonial project, it eventually became “indigenized” since native families viewed it as a venue for economic and social advancement, and lent political and material support to mission schools in their communities. Indeed, the idea that children should “learn the book” (an expression synonymous with acquisition of “wisdom of Europeans”), as Fr. Witte put it, was commonly accepted not only on the more “Europeanized” coast but also in the immediate interior of the colony.⁷ A number of Steyler missionaries who recounted their stories about the foundation of Catholic missions in various locations across the colony em-

phasized that generalized support of Togolese communities for the schooling project.

5. 2. Ritual

As the human body mediates between self and society, modern polities (including colonial polities) seek to “re-culturate” their subjects in terms of an empowered social script (*doxa*) – which corresponds to a current configuration of the field of power – through redefinition of apparently irrelevant bodily habits. The ultimate purpose of these practices is to reset the subjects’ *habitus* (embodied cultural behavior), and thus to shape a “new person,” as well as to relegate him/her to a “designated” location in social space enclosed within the established borders of that polity (cf. Comaroff 1992: 70).

Religious and political (e.g. national) rituals play an important, although a subsidiary role in that process, in the sense that they inculcate in people the symbolic, intellectual, emotional, and bodily “correctness” determined by dominant narratives. Similarly, the Catholic rituals – as a set of prescribed and controlled gestures performed within the institutional framework of the Steyler mission in German Togo – were to instill in African participants the behavior expected from members of the colonial polity, and – consequently – to establish new loyalties that separated neophytes from their traditional, non-Christian social and cultural settings. These included the individual “rites of passage” (baptism, the first communion, and confirmation) as well as the annual rituals that “re-segmented” and redefined astronomical time in terms of the Catholic ritual calendar (e.g. Christmas and Corpus Christi).

Thus, during the first decades of Catholic missionary work in the colony, most baptisms were administered not to babies but to children and young adults – that is, to individuals who would consciously conform to the prescribed ritual behavior. Gender differences were also clearly marked and enforced, as Catholic missionaries conducted separate (both in space and time) baptismal ceremonies for male and female candidates. More importantly, however, baptism was to mark a radical break of neophytes with their “pagan” environment. Indeed, the baptized girls ritually became “new persons,” with “new souls and bodies,” which was symbolized by their white dresses and new, baptismal names that they were given during the ceremony. In the final exhortation, the priest urged the neophytes to persevere in Catholic

5 *Aus Adjido*, Presse Togo, p. 96; Archive of SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536.

6 *Die Missionsstation von Porto Seguro*, Presse Togo, p. 83; Archive of SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536.

7 *Awoku's Tod und Begräbnis*, Presse Togo, p. 77; Archive of SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536.

faith and prayed for their families, “some of them still pagan,” so that they do not “interfere” with that process.⁸

While the government of German Togo introduced certain civic celebrations that were based on national symbolism, e.g. the Emperor’s Birthday (*Kaisergeburtstag*), the missionaries used their institutional and symbolic resources to transform indigenous conceptions of time according to the Christian ritual calendar. The Steyler missionaries and the SSpS sisters⁹ who worked in Togo left several interesting descriptions of such celebrations. At least two “disciplinary” or culture-transforming aspects of those annual events can be extracted from those accounts: their European, if not German symbolic content that was to be adopted by the Togolese; and certain ritualized drill to which the participants, in particular children, were submitted. The disciplinary aspect of Christmas manifested itself in the practice of “ranking” and “bodily drill/reform” of school children. The SSpS sisters who managed a school for girls in Lome, for instance, prepared and distributed among their students about one hundred gifts – such as European clothing, toys, and school supplies – not only to give girls Christmas joy but also to reward their docility as the sisters understood it: “O happy those who excelled in school attendance and diligence – wrote one of them – because they were honored accordingly.”¹⁰ In this way, however, the traditional large family as the principal reference group for an individual was being substituted by the Christian community of believers, and the collectivist attitudes with reference to the large family or clan were being gradually replaced by individualistic competitiveness.

6. Effects of Colonial Disciplining: the Aku Family

What impact did those administrative and cultural disciplining strategies have on Togolese families? Here, I present only one case, namely the family of Martin Aku, in which the features of “African colonial family” became particularly clearly manifest.



Fig. 2: Martin Aku (Westermann 1952: 245)

Martin Aku (1913-1970) was the Ewe-Togolese physician, author, and nationalist politician (Fig. 2). He was one of twelve children of Pastor Andreas Aku (1863-1931) – the first indigenous leader of the Ewe Presbyterian Church and one of the most eminent personalities produced by the North German Mission in Togo. As for his family life, mission-educated Andreas Aku was a strict disciplinarian who put an indelible stamp on the personality of his son. Indeed, although Martin was born only one year before the termination of the German rule in Togo, he was still, although indirectly, disciplined into what his father viewed as German values. “Life in our family was puritanically simple,” he remembered. “Everything was going according to certain rules. Each of us had a task to perform and woe to him if he or she failed. The family prayer began punctually at 5:00, which means that we had to get up even earlier. Afterwards we cleaned the house: bedrooms, the yard, and the street in front of the house. That was, of course, our sisters’ job. We boys took care of the garden. ... At six o’clock, there was another prayer service, this time at church, on Bagida

8 *Eine Tauffeier in Lome*, Presse Togo, p. 41; Archive of the SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536.

9 Sisters Servants of the Holy Spirit (SSpS) – the female missionary order founded by Arnold Janssen in 1889.

10 *Weihnachten in Lome*, Presse Togo, p. 44; Archive of SVD Generalate, Rome - 45.536

Street. ... Orderliness and punctuality were two values that our father adhered to rigorously, perhaps because they are not the strong side of our race." (Westermann 1952: 252; trans. - DJP). Moreover, Martin's father also drew clear-cut boundaries between the "pagan" and the Christian members of his own kin. After Martin had been born, his father "made sure that the pagan relatives did not stay long in the house and speak to the mother." He later remembered: "Most of my paternal relatives on the coast, where I grew up, were still pagans, and I had little contact with them because my father had drawn a clear line between Christians and pagans" (Westermann 1952: 244; transl. - DJP). In this way, however, Martin was socialized into a new, "Christian clan" whose boundaries cut across the traditional kin-based identities.

It was this sort of child-rearing in the Aku family, and specifically what Martin terms the *Geist* of his father, that ultimately shaped his *habitus* – the "embodied history" of his socialization – which made him act according to his father's will even in his absence. "I am grateful to my father for this education," Martin wrote in his memoirs; "later, when he became the head of the Ewe church in French Togo, and did not have much time left for the family life, his spirit (*Geist*) was always perceptible in our house, and even when he was away for a long time the same orderliness and punctuality regulated our life at home. ... We got used to our duties to the point that we always fulfilled them with love" (Westermann 1952: 246; trans. - DJP). It is not surprising, therefore, that when Martin Aku was sent to continue his studies in Germany, he was able to adjust himself to the school discipline – and to life in German society in general – relatively easily. "I was diligent, too," he remembered, "because there was nothing that could distract me. In this way – and through sheer necessity – I was able to fulfill my duties" (p. 273). All in all, he had only words of praise for "famous German virtues," in particular for the "German efficiency" – the "secret of the German self and its formidable effectiveness" (p. 275).

7. *Die Mischlinge* – Unwanted Fruit of "Dangerous Liaisons"

One important group of "in-betweens" on the German colonial frontier constituted individuals of "mixed blood" (*Mischlinge*). They even became the subject of a heated political debate that was based on the distinction between the white and the

black "races" viewed as oppositional and mutually excluding categories. This sharp differentiation was rooted in the Darwinist assumption that races, classes, and gender hierarchies were products of a long evolutionary process whose mechanism remained beyond human influence, which in turn implied compliance with "facts of nature" on individual and social levels. As such, racial hierarchies were also inscribed into sociopolitical practice of the colonial state.

Nevertheless, there existed multiple points of contact between white colonizers and the dark-skinned colonized that did not fit easily within the explicit racial categories. One of such junctures was sexuality – the area of praxis that was central to the contemporary bourgeois discrimination between the "internal" order and the "external" chaos and nature, as the above-quoted statements by Rohrbach clearly indicate. German colonial agents who spent some time in Togoland and other colonies, and who initially were almost exclusively bachelors, fathered a considerable number of children with indigenous women. Referring to that fact, Sprigade and Moisel, the authors of the "German Colonial Atlas" (1912) wrote: "The growing number of people of mixed blood is deplorable. This phenomenon should be attributed to Europeans who have been employed at the construction of railway lines, and as such it could be perhaps seen as an exception." Quoting an unidentified official report, they stated in conclusion: "The times come when the number of mixed blood people will exceed the number of Europeans. (Still), 'the fact that the problem of mixed-bloods exists, and it can become drastically evident also in Togo, is highly disturbing'" (Sprigade and Moisel 1912: 15; transl. DJP). At the time Sprigade and Moisel wrote these words, however, the number of Togo's *Mischlinge* (officially 263 but in fact about twice as high) had most likely already exceeded the number of all Europeans living there (368), including the missionaries.¹¹ Furthermore, the mixed-blood children were not only begotten by certain nationally undefined "Europeans employed at the railway construction sites," as the authors of the "Colonial Atlas" suggested, but also (and above all) by German traders and colonial officials; it was not an exception but rather a rule. Commenting on that phenomenon, Fr. Bücking, a Steyler missionary and the head of the Catholic Church in Togo, observed in 1899: "Wherever you

11 According to Steltzer (1984: 118), in 1913 there were 540 individuals of mixed blood and 534 whites living in Togo. See also Sebald (1988: 266).

go now, you can see harlots and concubines (in service of colonial officials), and the generation of mixed-bloods sprouts like weeds" (Sebald 1988: 477; transl. DJP). Similarly, Felix Bryk, a member of the *Reichstag*, put it frankly in the following words: "I do not know any healthy white man in the colonies who would not have any liaisons with black women; and this is valid for all social classes" (Petschull and Höpker 1984: 124). In fact, it was estimated that at the turn of the centuries about 90% of Europeans on the colonial frontier lived in various forms of concubinage with native women.

This situation also had certain impact on the economic condition of affected indigenous families. Before the establishment of direct colonial rule, traders active on the Slave Coast frequently entered relationships with local women that were regulated by consuetudinary law. Consequently, they had to provide for the offspring or faced the risk of losing their African trading partners and clientele. With the consolidation of the colonial polity, however, the interracial relations began to be increasingly dominated by the factor of force: cases of rape multiplied and obligations towards the begotten children were seldom fulfilled on individual level; they were not legally regulated by the state either. As contemporary author, August Wilhelm Schreiber from the North German Mission, observed: "The sums paid by particular men were usually very low, and even these were never stipulated by the administration" (Sebald 1988: 266f.).

How did the mixed-blood individuals experience their undefined status in the social space of colonial Togo? Petschull and Höpker collected testimonies of descendants of several high-ranking German colonial officials who were still living in Togo in the beginning of the 1980s. These were: Josef Köhler – the son of August Köhler, the governor of the colony in the years 1895-1902; Luise von Döring – the daughter of Hans-Georg von Döring, the chief commanding officer of the police troop in the years 1898-1910 and later, since 1911, the Speaker (*Erster Referent*) in the colonial government; Hans Gruner – the son of his famous father of the same name who commanded the German Hinterland Expedition in the years 1896-1898 and subsequently (since 1899) administered the district of Misahöhe (Fig. 3); Julia Pfennigweit – the daughter of the school director; and Otto Hundt – the son of a trader from Hamburg (Petschull and Höpker 1984: 119). Still, in accordance with the regulation issued in 1913, none of those individuals could use the family name of his

or her German father, and offenders were penalized with a high fine of 150 marks or a term in jail.¹²



Fig. 3: Hans Gruner, son of a district officer in German Togo (Petschull and Höpker 1984: 119)

Conclusion

The colonial state of German Togo provided the general spatial and institutional framework for reshaping the traditional conceptions about human being and the social fabric of local communities with the purpose of creating docile subjects of the empire. The project was carried on according to the then dominant ideological blueprint that included Christian, Positivist, and Darwinian components and reflected the shifting configuration of the field of power in Germany. Administrative and cultural means applied for this multi-layered purpose by the colonial polity, in cooperation with Christian missions, included, formal schooling of various levels, which was particularly effective in case of boarding schools for future native teachers (where students remained under a nearly perma-

12 *Amtsblatt für das Schutzgebiet Togo* 8: 1913, p. 313f.; Bundesarchiv Berlin - R 1001/4265.

ment control of school management, and hence out of their family circle and traditional cultural environment). Another such mechanism constituted the “correctional settlements” – institutionalized “melting pots” for the emerging colonial society – whose program cut across the existing ethnic and cultural divisions through intermarriage, the adoption of Western technologies as well as certain Ewe cultural features that were promoted by the colonizer, including the Ewe language standardized by missionary linguists.

Missions, on their part, further “re-formed” Togolese men and women through ritualism and inculcation of new bodily habits, which gradually created new loyalties and thus reshaped, to certain degree, the structure of traditional large families. One example of such transformation was the family in which Martin Aku, the Togolese physician and political activist, grew up. Another aspect of the colonial metamorphosis of Togolese families was the offspring of extramarital relations between local women and German officials – a phenomenon that presented a serious challenge both to the established local standards of family solidarity and to the then valid European conceptions about personal integrity and race.

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